
Case Study: Everspring Inn Unlawful Mass Evictions during the COVID-19 Pandemic

Overview of Events

In August 2020, tenants at the Everspring Inn, located at 8201 Aurora Ave N, were unlawfully evicted amidst a declared public health emergency. Despite multiple urgent complaints flooding the Seattle Department of Construction and Inspections (SDCI) portal, the department failed to respond adequately. These evictions occurred shortly after the Seattle Police Department issued a **Chronic Nuisance Property Declaration** to the owner, Myung Ha Kang (Ryan Kang), demanding corrective action for ongoing criminal activities at the property.

Chronology of Complaints and SDCI's Failures

1. August 18, 2020:

- **Complaint #007155-20CP:** Tenants reported a mass eviction in progress, with water shut off, windows boarded up, and hired security intimidating residents. Despite the severity, the complaint was marked as "Admin Closure" on the same day with no inspection or follow-up.
- **Complaint #007945-20CP:** Reports of tenants being locked out and doors boarded were submitted. This complaint was also marked "Admin Closure" without investigation.
- **Complaint #007163-20CP:** Tenants explicitly described unlawful evictions taking place. Again, this was marked "Admin Closure" on the same day.

2. Resolution Failures:

- SDCI labeled these complaints as "Voluntary Compliance" and closed them without conducting an inspection, despite clear violations of tenant protections during a pandemic.
- This lack of action left residents homeless, exposed to further risks amidst COVID-19, and denied their legal rights to safe housing.

Key Violations and Oversight

- **Eviction Ban Ignored:** At the time, Washington State had implemented eviction moratoriums to protect tenants during COVID-19. SDCI failed to enforce these protections, allowing illegal actions by the property owner to proceed unchecked.
- **Pattern of Negligence:** Complaints from the same property had been filed as far back as 2013, with unresolved issues persisting into 2020. Notices of Violation (NOVs) were ignored or insufficiently enforced, enabling chronic noncompliance.
- **Permitting Irregularities:** Despite ongoing violations, construction permits were later issued to convert the motel into a hotel, raising questions about regulatory oversight and enforcement priorities.

Impact on Tenants

- Tenants were left on the streets during a public health emergency, facing unsafe conditions without access to basic utilities like water and shelter.
- SDCI's administrative closure of complaints eroded public trust in its ability to uphold housing standards and protect vulnerable populations.

Proposed Placement

This case can serve as a **primary example of systemic failure** and should be included in:

1. **Chapter: Systemic Oversight Failures:** Highlighting the deliberate administrative closures and lack of enforcement during a critical time.
2. **Chapter: Case Studies and Evidence:** As a key example of tenant vulnerability and the consequences of SDCI's inaction.